CONCEPT NOTE
OFFICIAL VIRTUAL SIDE EVENT
2026 UN WATER CONFERENCE

FROM PRESENCE TO INFLUENCE: YOUNG WOMEN RESHAPING MULTILATERAL WATER DECISIONS

Date	Saturday 5 December 2026 · 18:00–19:30 Abu Dhabi time (GST)
Format	Virtual, 90 minutes, English. Live captioning and a moderated chat; contributions in Spanish and other languages welcomed through the chat and interpreted by organisers where possible.
Interactive Dialogue	Water in multilateral processes (primary); Water for people (secondary)
Organizers	The AWA Project (lead) and South Asia Young Women in Water (SAYWiW)
Registration	theawaproject.org/un-water-conference

Young women are increasingly invited into multilateral water processes, yet being in the room does not mean shaping what leaves it. This virtual side event centres young women from the Global South, with an intersectional lens that brings in Indigenous young women and the wider youth constituency, to examine what separates presence from influence. Speakers from South Asia, Latin America and other Global South regions, working across economics, food security, climate, health, biodiversity and diplomacy, will share how they have moved agendas, and where they have been blocked. An interactive segment will capture participants' own barriers and proposals in real time. The results will feed a co-authored policy op-ed with concrete recommendations for multilateral institutions, a virtual follow-up session, and a cross-regional peer network of young women in water.

1. Background and rationale

Young women are increasingly invited into international and multilateral forums, yet participation alone does not guarantee influence. They may be present without shaping agendas, contributing to decisions, or seeing their recommendations reflected in institutional action. The numbers point to how far there is to go: people aged 30 or under hold only 2.8% of parliamentary seats worldwide, and young women just 1.2% (IPU, 2026). In the water sector itself, women make up fewer than one in five water utility workers (World Bank, 2019). The decision-making spaces where water policy is set remain, in both age and gender, far from the people most affected by it.

For young women from the Global South, the barriers begin long before the meeting starts. Most multilateral processes are still convened in the Global North, and visa requirements, travel costs, limited institutional affiliation and English-dominant procedures determine who can attend at all, a form of passport privilege that is rarely acknowledged. Cultural and family expectations, care responsibilities and limited familiarity with multilateral systems add further hurdles to even considering participation. These barriers compound for Indigenous young women, who also face language barriers, distance from capitals, and the under-recognition of the traditional and territorial knowledge they hold about water.

Indigenous Peoples make up around 6% of the world's population, yet their voices remain marginal in global water governance (World Bank, 2019).

This initiative moves the conversation beyond representation as a numerical achievement. Keeping young women at its heart, it adopts an intersectional approach and asks what young women contribute, what enables their ideas to carry weight, and what institutions must change so participation becomes meaningful rather than symbolic, avoiding the "youth-washing" and tokenism that often accompany inclusion efforts. Water provides a compelling entry point because it is not a stand-alone sector: it connects economic development, food security, climate adaptation, health, biodiversity, diplomacy and social equity. Bringing these perspectives together demonstrates that effective water decisions require diverse forms of knowledge and lived experience.

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2. Objectives

To create a practical, participatory platform where young women, particularly from the Global South, can understand how influence is built within multilateral water processes, learn from experienced professionals across sectors and regions, and define the institutional changes needed to make their participation meaningful. While young women are the protagonists of the event, it is open to all: institutional representatives, senior practitioners and other stakeholders are invited to participate as listeners and allies, since they are key to driving the changes the event calls for.

Specific objectives

- Show how expertise from economics, food security, climate, health, biodiversity and diplomacy strengthens water-related decision-making.
- Identify the difference between being invited into a process and being able to influence its direction or outcomes.
- Make visible the specific barriers faced by young women from the Global South, including Indigenous young women, from visas and funding to language and the recognition of traditional knowledge.
- Share concrete strategies that have helped young women navigate and influence multilateral spaces.
- Generate practical recommendations for multilateral institutions, networks and emerging professionals.
- Build a foundation for continued engagement, knowledge products and advocacy after the event.

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3. Intended impact

The initiative aims to create impact at three connected levels. For participants, it should increase confidence, practical understanding and readiness to engage in multilateral processes. For the wider professional community, it should strengthen recognition of interdisciplinary, territorially grounded and gendered expertise. For institutions, it should provide a clear, evidence-based account of the barriers that prevent meaningful participation and the actions required to address them.

- **Immediate impact:** participants gain useful insights, contacts, language and examples that help them engage more effectively.
- **Short-term impact:** audience evidence and speaker experiences are turned into a policy op-ed and a summary of recommendations, shared directly with the Conference Secretariat, UN-Water members

and youth water networks, and discussed at a virtual follow-up session.

- **Long-term impact:** a cross-regional peer network of young women in water sustains the conversation, and multilateral institutions adopt more accessible, decentralised, inclusive and accountable pathways for young women to contribute to agenda-setting and decisions.

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4. Who the initiative is for

The primary audience is young women professionals, researchers, practitioners, students and advocates from the Global South, including Indigenous young women, who work in water or related fields and want to engage with international policy processes. Secondary audiences include multilateral institutions, funders, civil-society organisations, youth networks, professional networks and senior practitioners seeking to improve how they engage emerging professionals. Participation is open to all; young women lead the conversation, while other participants are invited to listen and commit.

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5. Expected outputs and commitments

- **Policy op-ed (2–3 pages)** on why meaningful participation matters and practical measures for international organisations. Co-authored by SAYWiW and AWA, published on both organisations' channels within two months of the Conference and circulated to institutional partners.
- **Barriers and recommendations summary:** audience-identified barriers and proposed institutional responses.
- **Digital content:** short pieces with key messages, anonymised audience insights and speaker advice.
- **Virtual follow-up session** within three months, to report back on the op-ed's circulation and progress on commitments, co-hosted by SAYWiW and AWA.
- **Global South peer network** of young women water professionals.

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6. How success will be assessed

- Diversity of sectors, regions and backgrounds represented among speakers and participants.
- Level of participation, measured by number of registrants and attendees, poll responses, and questions and contributions in the chat.
- Number and quality of barriers, recommendations and commitments captured during the session.
- Short closing survey: share of respondents reporting improved understanding of multilateral processes and of how to influence them.
- Publication and circulation of the policy op-ed, and number of institutions and networks reached.
- Follow-up: delivery of the virtual follow-up session, and evidence of action by partners or institutions.

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7. Core message

> **Young women do not need only a seat in the room; they need fair access to the knowledge, networks, resources and decision-making pathways that allow their expertise to shape**

outcomes.

For young women from the Global South, that also means removing the barriers that decide who reaches the room in the first place. By combining cross-sector and cross-regional experience with the direct input of participants, this initiative will turn a conversation about inclusion into practical guidance for influence and institutional change.

References

- Inter-Parliamentary Union (2026). *Youth participation in national parliaments.* Geneva: IPU.
- World Bank (2019). *Women in Water Utilities: Breaking Barriers.* Washington, DC: World Bank.
- World Bank (2026). *Indigenous Peoples* (overview). worldbank.org/en/topic/indigenouspeoples.